



ULAB
UNIVERSITY OF LIBERAL ARTS
BANGLADESH

Blog Writing

Course Name: Communication and Technology
Course Code: MSJ2101
Semester: Fall 2022

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Mahjabin Haque: An excellent inspiration for women Engineering

NASA was created in significant part as a reaction to the Soviet Sputnik launch in 1957. The National Advisory Committee for Aeronautics, or NACA, was its focal point. Congress established it in 1915. NASA was already operational when President John F. Kennedy claimed that the US would send a man to the moon by the end of the 1960s. American astronaut Neil Armstrong became the first person to step foot on the Moon in 1969 as part of the Apollo program, which was founded in order to complete this. Later, unmanned missions like Viking, Mariner, Voyager, and Galileo investigated additional solar system bodies. A Bangladeshi woman Mahjabin Haque got the opportunity to work with them in 2019.



Mahjabin Haque Photo: Courtesy. A woman from Bangladesh working as a space system software developer for NASA

The US and the rest of the world have been led by NASA's Lyndon B. Johnson Space Center (JSC) on an ongoing adventure of space exploration, discovery, and accomplishment for more than 50

years. Earlier in 2019, around the time of the 50th anniversary of the Apollo 11 moon landing, a young woman from Bangladesh named Mahjabin Haque completed her second internship with NASA. She had always aspired to work for NASA, the National Aeronautics and Space Administration, in the US. She wanted to be a part of NASA's mission to send people to the moon and was fascinated by the reports that they were doing so. (Ahmad, 2019)



Photo: *The Daily Star*, Mahjabin's dream job in NASA

At the NASA Johnson Space Center in Houston, Texas, Mahjabin started her dream work as a space system software engineer, after graduating in computer science from the College of Engineering at Wayne State University in Michigan. Mahjabin worked as an intern for two NASA divisions when she was a student at Wayne State University. She originally began working as a data analyst at the Houston, Texas-based Johnson Space Center for NASA. In the wake of it, she began her internship as a software engineer at the Mission Control Center. She was employed at the center in programming support, software design, testing, and maintenance. She gained an amazing résumé and professional experience during her four-month internships in both professions. (Idrak, 2019)

Mahjabin, her mother Ferdousi Chowdhury, her father Syed Enamul Haque, a banker, and their lone younger brother Syed Samiul Haque moved to the US from their native Sylhet in 2009 after winning a diversity visa (often referred to as the DV lottery). Currently, Samiul is employed with the US Army. She knows six languages, including English, Bangla, Hindi, Urdu, Spanish, Gujarati, and Punjabi.

In an Interview with Dhaka Tribune, she said for young girls “I would advise them to pursue their goals bravely. Failure is OK. Despite my numerous failures, I pursued my goals and put in even more effort. If you put in the effort and remain true to yourself, dreams can come true.”

Learnings and Outcomes (Self-reflection):

- I learned how to write a blog post.
- I can now explain the importance of equal opportunities for women in STEM.
- I understood how a real success story can inspire other people.
- I learned how to collect information from different sources into one story.